

FAWZAN HUSAIN



9. Mrinalini Mukherjee *(1949-2015)*

10. Meera Mukherjee *(1923-1998)*

thing unsaid. Where Menon gives us mystery, **Nilima Sheikh** (1945—) is a more transparent storyteller, sometimes making us confront familiar but appalling narratives about the condition of women. We are disoriented as we encounter a sombre theme like bride-burning, rendered on a small scale, with a light palette and watercolour medium, or as we walk into an installation of screens that seemed innocuously inviting from across the room. When drawing inspiration from Rajput and Mughal miniature paintings, she revisits one concern of Abanindranath's Bengal School while, at last, evolving a truly modern idiom rather than merely lapsing into an atavistic one. Sharing a feminist outlook, and even more contemporary in rendering, is the work of **Nalini Malani** (1946—), which encompasses video as well as traditional media. Born in Karachi of mixed parentage, she was a child of Partition, and stands in this list for many such migrants. While class privilege might have helped her surpass that trauma, India's continuing religious conflict keeps it painfully in focus.

Women are also numbered among the preeminent sculptors of the post-Independence period. My choice, to complete our team, is of the two Mukherjees, both of whom died, not as outrageously young as Sher-Gil, but sooner than they might have. **Meera Mukherjee** (1923-98) is one of the great 20th century 'primitivists'. Rejecting her western academic training, she lived in the tribal Bastar district of Chhattisgarh to learn the region's tradition of bronze sculpture. She identified as an artisan as much as an artist; but while she adhered closely, and persistently, to the medium and style of an established craft, she also transformed it, especially through the enhancement of scale and allusion to contemporary political issues. It was an encounter with craft that similarly led **Mrinalini Mukherjee** (1949-2015) to engage with knotted hemp as a medium. Though her ambiguously figurative works often bear titles that point to rural deities, she did not follow any single vernacular tradition closely. The powerful life force, combined with unfamiliar anatomy, suggests alien presences. In her later years, she experimented with ceramic and bronze, producing forms that again often suggest ancient, unknown forms of life. Both Mukherjees embodied a single-mindedness and dedication to work, on a Barbara Hepworth scale that must excite awe and, in some of us, a measure of self-reproach. ■